

Political Behaviour and Parties in Central and Eastern Europe

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Course description:

How do people vote? How stable are the parties?, or What are the main issues on the political agenda? These questions are often answered in political science based solely on the Western experience. In this course, we will explore the political behaviour of people, parties and party systems from a Central and Eastern European (CEE) perspective. High volatility of parties, unstable party system, low partisanship and disengagement with politics are some of the few particularities of the CEE parties and voters. We will account for the historical legacies of totalitarian regimes, the process of democratization and the challenges of the transition to explain these issues, and we will look at how well classical theories in political behaviour and party systems can be applied to the political context of Central and Eastern European countries.

The first part of the course will focus on the parties and party systems in Central and Eastern Europe. We will discuss how left and right are different in these countries, what the main cleavages are, and the stability and change of the parties and party systems. In the second part of the course, we will look more at individual political behaviour, focusing on the effects of living in the communist regime and the years of transitions. In the last lesson, we will also discuss the main attitudes in CEE towards current international developments. In the final part, students will present how their research interests can be explored in the region, looking at already existing studies and proposing new research ideas. From a methodological perspective, throughout the course, we will try to answer the question of how different these

countries are today compared to the Western ones and how we can include them in future research.

Teaching Objectives:

- Students will learn the main characteristics of Central and Eastern European politics;
- Students should be able to account for regional and historical differences in their future works;
- Students will be up-to-date with the most recent developments in the field, including the use of advanced methods to study less accessible regions;
- Students should be motivated after this course to include CEE countries in their own research and understand the limitations of Western-centred studies;

Lessons outline:

24 September 2025

Lesson 1: Intro Lecture: Why to study Central and Eastern Europe

3 October 2025:

Lesson 2 (9:15 – 10:45): Historical context: Communist and pre-communist legacies

Required readings:

- Berend, Ivan T. 2005. “What Is Central and Eastern Europe?” *European Journal of Social Theory* 8 (4): 401–16. doi:10.1177/1368431005056420.
- Pop-Eleches, Grigore, and Joshua A. Tucker. 2017. *Communism’s Shadow: Historical Legacies and Contemporary Political Attitudes*. Princeton Studies in Political Behavior. Princeton, New Jersey: Princeton University Press. [Chapter 2, Section 2.2]

Optional readings:

- Verdery, Katherine. 2018. “Revelations.” In *My Life as a Spy: Investigations in a Secret Police File*, 195–226. Duke University Press, <https://doi.org/10.2307/j.ctv1220jzc.10>.

Lesson 3 (11:00 – 12:30): Dimensions of political conflict: GAL-TAN and Left-Right
Required readings:

- Kosteletzky, Tomas. 2002. "The Party System: A Product of a Country's History and Culture?" in *Political parties after communism: Developments in East-Central Europe*. Washington, DC: Woodrow Wilson Center Press.
- Marks, Gary, Liesbet Hooghe, Moira Nelson, and Erica Edwards. 2006. "Party Competition and European Integration in the East and West: Different Structure, Same Causality." *Comparative Political Studies* 39 (2): 155–75. doi:10.1177/0010414005281932.

Optional readings:

- Rovny, Jan, and Erica E. Edwards. 2012. "Struggle over Dimensionality: Party Competition in Western and Eastern Europe." *East European Politics and Societies: And Cultures* 26 (1): 56–74. doi:10.1177/0888325410387635.
- Coman, Emanuel. 2017. "Dimensions of Political Conflict in West and East: An Application of Vote Scaling to 22 European Parliaments." *Party Politics* 23 (3): 248–61. doi:10.1177/1354068815593454.

Lesson 4 (14:00 – 15:30): Party system formation and change
Required readings:

- Haughton, Tim, and Kevin Deegan-Krause. 2015. "Hurricane Season: Systems of Instability in Central and East European Party Politics." *East European Politics and Societies: And Cultures* 29 (1): 61–80. doi:10.1177/0888325414566072.
- Emanuele, Vincenzo, Alessandro Chiaramonte, and Sorina Soare. 2020. "Does the Iron Curtain Still Exist? The Convergence in Electoral Volatility between Eastern and Western Europe." *Government and Opposition* 55 (2): 308–26. doi:10.1017/gov.2018.25.

Optional readings:

- Rovny, Jan, and Jonathan Polk. 2017. “Stepping in the Same River Twice: Stability amidst Change in Eastern European Party Competition.” *European Journal of Political Research* 56 (1): 188–98. doi:10.1111/1475-6765.12163.
- Engler, Sarah. 2016. “Corruption and Electoral Support for New Political Parties in Central and Eastern Europe.” *West European Politics* 39 (2): 278–304. doi:10.1080/01402382.2015.1084127.

4 October 2025:

Lesson 5 (9:15 – 10:45): Evolution of far-right populist parties and democratic backsliding

Required readings:

- Enyedi, Zsolt. 2020. “Right-Wing Authoritarian Innovations in Central and Eastern Europe.” *East European Politics* 36 (3): 363–77. doi:10.1080/21599165.2020.1787162.
- Vachudova, Anna Milada. 2020. “Ethnopolitism and Democratic Backsliding in Central Europe.” *East European Politics* 36 (3): 318–40. doi:10.1080/21599165.2020.1787163.

Optional readings:

- Cianetti, Licia, James Dawson, and Seán Hanley. 2018. “Rethinking ‘Democratic Backsliding’ in Central and Eastern Europe – Looking beyond Hungary and Poland.” *East European Politics* 34 (3): 243–56. doi:10.1080/21599165.2018.1491401.
- Santana, Andrés, Piotr Zagórski, and José Rama. 2020. “At Odds with Europe: Explaining Populist Radical Right Voting in Central and Eastern Europe.” *East European Politics* 36 (2): 288–309. doi:10.1080/21599165.2020.1737523.

Lesson 6 (11:00 – 12:30): Political attitudes formation and change: Early political socialisation under the communist regime, socio-demographics, immigration

Required readings:

- Pop-Eleches, Grigore, and Joshua A. Tucker. 2020. “Communist Legacies and Left-Authoritarianism.” *Comparative Political Studies* 53 (12): 1861–89. doi:10.1177/0010414019879954.

- Dinas, Elias, and Ksenia Northmore-Ball. 2020. “The Ideological Shadow of Authoritarianism.” *Comparative Political Studies* 53 (12): 1957–91. doi:10.1177/0010414019852699.

Optional readings:

- Jastramskis, Mažvydas, Vytautas Kuokštis, and Matas Baltrukevičius. 2021. “Retrospective Voting in Central and Eastern Europe: Hyper-Accountability, Corruption or Socio-Economic Inequality?” *Party Politics* 27 (4): 667–79. doi:10.1177/1354068819880320.
- Pop-Eleches, Grigore. 2025. “The Perfect Storm: Political Alienation, Ideological Resonance, and the Role of Influencers in the 2024 Romanian Parliamentary Elections.” *East European Politics* 41 (3): 370–400. doi:10.1080/21599165.2025.2524502.
- Szulecki, Kacper, Michał Kotnarowski, and Ben Stanley. 2023. “Emigrant External Voting in Central-Eastern Europe after EU Enlargement.” *Electoral Studies* 81 (February): 102552. doi:10.1016/j.electstud.2022.102552.

Lesson 7 (14:00 – 15:30): Political participation: voting and protests

Required readings:

- Kostelka, Filip and Eva Krejcova. forthcoming, “Electoral Behaviour: Voter Turnout and Vote Choice” in Adam Fagan, Petra Guasti, and Petr Kopecky (ed.), *The Routledge Handbook of East European Politics*.
- Bernhard, Michael. 2020. “What Do We Know about Civil Society and Regime Change Thirty Years after 1989?” *East European Politics* 36 (3): 341–62. doi:10.1080/21599165.2020.1787160.

Optional Readings:

- Kostelka, Filip, and Jan Rovny. 2019. “It’s Not the Left: Ideology and Protest Participation in Old and New Democracies.” *Comparative Political Studies* 52 (11): 1677–1712. doi:10.1177/0010414019830717.

- Gherghina, Sergiu, Joakim Ekman, and Olena Podolian. 2023. “When Promises Reach Boundaries: Political Participation in Post-Communist Countries.” *European Societies* 25 (2): 268–80. doi:10.1080/14616696.2023.2178187.

21 November 2025

Lesson 8 (9:15 – 10:45): Attitudes towards international actors: EU, NATO, US, Russia (optional or student presentations)

- Neumann, Iver B. 1999. Making Regions: Central Europe in *Uses of the Other: “The East” in European Identity Formation*. Borderlines, v. 9. Minneapolis: University of Minnesota Press.
- Tucker, Joshua A., Alexander C. Pacek, and Adam J. Berinsky. 2002. “Transitional Winners and Losers: Attitudes toward EU Membership in Post-Communist Countries.” *American Journal of Political Science* 46 (3): 557. doi:10.2307/3088399.

Lesson 9 (11:00 – 12:30): Advances in Political Science Research on Central and Eastern Europe (optional or student presentations)

- Bernhard, Michael, and Krzysztof Jasiewicz. 2015. “Whither Eastern Europe?: Changing Approaches and Perspectives on the Region in Political Science.” *East European Politics and Societies: And Cultures* 29 (2): 311–22. doi:10.1177/0888325415587919.

Lesson 10 (14:00 – 15:30): Student presentations

21 November 2025

Lesson 11 (9:15 – 10:45): Student presentations

Lesson 12 (11:00 – 12:30): Student presentations

Lesson 13 (14:00 – 15:30): Student presentations